ally knew about it, or even bothered. Even when I was world number two for many years, there wasn't this kind of attention. Today, thanks to social media and live-streaming, there's increased passion for the game among the common man."

Women's chess in India has come a long way from the time of Bombay's Khadilkar Sisters—Vasanti, Jayshree and Rohini—recognised as pioneers of the game. The trio dominated the National Women's Chess Championship since its inception in 1974 up to 1984. The likes of Bhagyashree Sathe Thipsay, Anupama Gokhale née Abhyankar and Subbaraman Vijayalakshmi fared well at the Asia level, but it was with Humpy that an Indian woman made an impact on the global scene; she remains the only Indian to be a challenger to the world champion in 2011. She'd win the world junior title and become the second female player after the legendary Judith Polgár to exceed the 2600 Elo rating mark.



ANDREY ANOSOV/FIDE

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>
> **KONERU HUMPY**
> *India's first female chess Grandmaster*

GETTING PAST THE GLASS CEILING

Still, her solitary exploits haven't made India a chess powerhouse. While Humpy has seen doors open for her female peers, be it with the number of dedicated tournaments, the increase in prize money or the rise in corporate sponsorships, chess remains out of reach for many. Training costs are high and tournaments are often held abroad, and women struggle to survive professionally. While Humpy is happy about the increase in accessibility to training resources with the internet, the ability to rope in top coaches and seconds (aides who help a player prepare for and analyse games) comes at a steep price. In an interview to INDIA TODAY in December 2024, Divya noted that progress has been made, but what is lacking is investment in "young talents who need it". Even a prodigy like her has no sponsors and depends on cash prizes and her doctor parents to foot the costs. The FIDE Cup win, one hopes, changes things for Divya just as it did for Gukesh.

The ratio of male to female players in India continues to be skewed in favour of the former. It's best reflected in how, out of India's 88 Grandmasters, only four are women. No Indian woman has been world champion. Much of this disparity boils down to opportunity, feels Kunte. "If you see the men's calendar, it is full. They don't have time with tournaments on the FIDE circuit, Freestyle Chess, open tournaments and leagues." Women-only tournaments with a decent winners' fee are few and far between. "For women to show their class, they have to wait," adds Kunte. "They don't have an option and have to fight it out with men in the open section—which is tough. Some people get dejected by the performances. It's not just about accumulating experience, you also want to build a career in the sport." There's hope, though, as tournaments like Tata Steel India, which have equal prize pools for men and women, show that gender parity may slowly be making its way into chess.

The onus falls on women, too, to improve their game. Ask any top female player and they all emphasise the significance of playing against men to raise their calculative power. "Having women-only tournaments is good for professional players to sustain careers but, to improve, you definitely need to compete with men [in open tournaments]," says Humpy. "Only playing women tournaments can lead to stagnation because the number of players is limited and you end up meeting the same ones often. The chances of the mind fighting further and finding an improvisational way is less." Divya herself competed in two open events in Prague and Wijk aan Zee in the Netherlands early this year and had a tough run of results, including losing a classical game to an 11-year-old. Anand agrees with Humpy's assessment, saying, "Perhaps Divya playing these difficult tournaments is what culminated in this [World Cup] victory."

Efforts are being made to increase female participation in the game. The All India Chess Federation (AICF) runs The Smart Girl Project aimed at grassroots development and early engagement with the game. Additionally, in the first quarter, it distributed quarterly stipends ranging from Rs 60,000-1,50,000 to 21 top female players across the under-7 and under-19 categories to support players' coaching and travel needs, enabling them to compete globally. "Our goal is to create a robust, inclusive ecosystem, where every girl with a passion for chess finds opportunity, support, and recognition," says Nitin Narang, president of AICF. The Federation has hosted two editions of FIDE Women's Grand Prix events in recent years, giving Indian players the necessary international exposure.

In addition to equal attention, equal respect is another thing women chess players could do with. Much like their compatriots in cricket and football, they, too, have to strive for credence and to be taken seriously. In a viral post shared in January 2024, Divya detailed her frustrations about the excessive scrutiny women in the game face, particularly with regard to their appearance. "I got told by people how the audience was not even bothered with the game but instead focused on every single other possible thing in the world—my clothes, hair, accent and every other irrelevant thing," she wrote. "...The sad truth is that when women play chess, people often overlook how good they actually are... Women are underappreciated... [they] should start getting equal respect." With her latest win, Divya may have earned exactly that for her cohort. ■